

STARTER

Field-by-Field DS-160 Walkthrough

United States - Tourist Visa (B-2)

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Before you start

The DS-160 (Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application) is completed at ceac.state.gov and is required for every B-2 tourist visa application. There's no way to save a partial application to finish later on a different device with the same session, so gather everything below before you open the form.

- Valid passport (check the expiry date - most posts want it valid well beyond your planned stay)
- Any previous U.S. visas or passports that show earlier U.S. travel
- Your full travel itinerary if you have one: dates, cities, accommodation address
- U.S. point of contact - name and address of who you're visiting or where you're staying, even a hotel
- Your current employer's name, address, and your job title (or school details if a student)
- A digital photo taken in the last 6 months meeting the State Department's photo requirements (square, plain light background, no glasses, no headwear except for religious reasons)

SAVE YOUR APPLICATION ID

The DS-160 gives you an Application ID the moment you start (top right of the screen). Write it down immediately - it's the only way to resume the form if your session times out, and you'll need it again to schedule your interview.

Section-by-section

1. Personal Information

Enter your name exactly as printed in your passport. If you have ever used another name (maiden name, name change, alternate spelling), declare it in "Other Names Used" - leaving this blank when it applies is one of the most common triggers for extra scrutiny.

2. Travel Information

Purpose of trip: select “Temporary Visitor for Pleasure (B2)” (or “Visit”, wording varies slightly by version of the form). You'll then choose whether your travel plans are specific or not yet finalized:

- If you have real dates and bookings, mark it specific and enter them - this is generally stronger
- If you're not sure of exact dates, you can mark it as not specific, but be ready to describe your general plans clearly at interview - vague on paper and vague in person is a weak combination

Give an address in the U.S. even if it's a hotel you haven't booked yet - a placeholder is fine, but it should be a real, plausible address you could actually stay at.

3. Travel Companions

List anyone traveling with you who is also applying for a visa around the same time. If your spouse or children are applying separately, note that here so the accounts are consistent with each other - reviewing officers do cross-check linked applications.

4. Previous U.S. Travel & Visa History

Answer completely and honestly, including any prior visa refusals, cancellations, or immigration violations (even a minor overstay). This section is checked against government records - an inconsistency here is far more damaging than the underlying fact would have been on its own.

5. Address, Phone, and Passport Information

Straightforward, but double-check the passport number and issue/expiry dates character by character against the passport itself - typos here can cause processing delays.

6. U.S. Point of Contact

A friend, relative, hotel, or even a tour operator. If you don't know anyone in the U.S. and aren't sure what to enter, a hotel's name, address, and phone number is an acceptable and common answer.

7. Family Information

Parents' names and, if applicable, spouse's details. Keep it consistent with what you enter elsewhere (e.g. marital status earlier in the form).

8. Work / Education / Training Information

Current employer or school, your role, monthly income if employed, and a brief description of duties. This section is one of the strongest places to demonstrate ties to your home country - a stable job or ongoing studies you're expected back for works in your favor.

9. Security and Background Questions

A standard set of eligibility questions (health, criminal history, security concerns, prior immigration violations). The overwhelming majority of applicants answer “No” to all of them, truthfully. Answer honestly regardless - these are checked against records, and a false answer is a far more serious problem than most true ones would have been.

10. Photo Upload

The form validates your photo automatically against composition and background rules. If it's rejected, don't just re-crop the same photo - retake it against a plain light background with even lighting; that's the most common reason for repeated rejections.

11. Review and Submit

Review every section before submitting - once submitted, the DS-160 generally can't be edited. After submission you'll get a confirmation page with a barcode; print it (or save the PDF) and bring it to your interview. You'll need the barcode number again when you pay the visa fee and schedule your appointment.